

Food & Cooking

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NOUNS

recipe

a set of instructions for preparing a dish

She followed the recipe exactly and it turned out perfectly.

portion

an amount of food served to one person

The portions were enormous. I couldn't finish mine.

leftovers

food remaining after a meal

We had the leftovers for lunch the next day.

cuisine

a style of cooking associated with a country or region

Japanese cuisine is known for its freshness and simplicity.

texture

the feel or consistency of food in the mouth

The cake had a lovely light, fluffy texture.

palate

a person's ability to taste and appreciate food and drink

She has a very refined palate. She can identify flavours most people miss.

ingredient

any of the foods or substances that are combined to make a dish

The recipe only has five ingredients.

snack

a small amount of food eaten between meals

I usually have a snack around mid-morning.

takeaway

a meal bought ready-cooked from a restaurant to eat elsewhere, or the restaurant that sells it

Friday nights are always a takeaway and a film.

seasoning

salt, pepper, herbs, or spices added to food to improve flavour

The dish just needed a little more seasoning.

gastronomy

the art and science of good food and cooking

The region is famous for its gastronomy and wine.

ADJECTIVES

raw

(of food) not cooked

Sushi is made with raw fish.

delicious

extremely pleasant to taste

The cake was absolutely delicious.

homemade

made at home rather than bought from a shop

Nothing beats homemade bread fresh from the oven.

bland

lacking flavour or taste; not seasoned enough

The soup was a bit bland. It needed salt and pepper.

spicy

having a strong, hot flavour from spices

The curry was too spicy for me. My eyes were watering.

tasty

having a pleasant, enjoyable flavour

The soup was really tasty. What did you put in it?

starving

extremely hungry (informal/exaggerated)

I haven't eaten since breakfast. I'm absolutely starving.

mouth-watering

looking or smelling extremely appetising

The smell from the kitchen was absolutely mouth-watering.

peckish

slightly hungry (British informal)

I'm a bit peckish. Shall we grab something?

artisanal

made in a traditional, non-industrial way using high-quality ingredients

The market sells artisanal bread and locally sourced cheese.

famished

extremely hungry

I was famished by the time we finally sat down to eat.

dietary

relating to the food a person regularly eats

She has specific dietary requirements: no gluten or dairy.

overcooked

cooked for too long, resulting in poor taste or texture

The steak was overcooked: dry and chewy.

savoury

having a salty or spicy flavour rather than a sweet one

I prefer savoury food to sweet. Give me cheese over cake any day.

al dente

(of pasta) cooked so it is still firm when bitten

Good pasta should always be al dente, never mushy.

VERBS

chop

to cut food into small pieces with a knife

Chop the onions finely before adding them to the pan.

boil

to cook food in water at 100°C

Boil the pasta for ten minutes until al dente.

simmer

to cook food gently in liquid just below boiling point

Let the sauce simmer on low heat for twenty minutes.

grate

to shred food into small pieces using a grater

Grate the cheese and sprinkle it over the top.

fry

to cook food in hot oil or fat

She fried the eggs in butter.

stir

to mix food by moving a spoon around in it

Stir the sauce every few minutes to stop it sticking.

marinate

to soak food in a flavoured liquid before cooking

Marinate the chicken overnight for the best flavour.

infuse

to soak or steep something to extract its flavour

The oil is infused with garlic and rosemary.

PHRASAL VERBS

heat up

to make food warm or hot, especially something already cooked

I'll just heat up the leftovers for dinner.

eat out

to have a meal at a restaurant rather than at home

We eat out about once a week.

dig in

to start eating enthusiastically

The food's on the table, so dig in whenever you're ready.

cut down on

to eat or drink less of something, especially for health reasons

He's trying to cut down on red meat.

cater for

to provide what is needed, especially food, for a particular group of people

The restaurant caters for vegetarians, vegans and coeliacs.

polish off

to finish all of a meal or dish quickly

The kids polished off the entire pizza in ten minutes.

whip up

to quickly and easily prepare a meal or dish

She whipped up a pasta dish in about fifteen minutes.

order in

to have food delivered to your home rather than cooking or eating out

None of us felt like cooking, so we ordered in some Thai food.

wolf down

to eat something very quickly and greedily, with little chewing or manners

He wolfed down his breakfast and ran out the door.

COLLOCATIONS**from scratch**

made entirely from basic ingredients, not from a packet or mix

She makes all her pasta from scratch.

comfort food

something you eat for emotional reassurance rather than hunger, often associated with childhood or home

When I'm feeling low, mashed potato is my comfort food.

go-to dish

the meal someone regularly cooks because they know it well and it always turns out right

Chilli con carne is my go-to dish when I've got people coming round.

picky eater

a person who is very fussy about the food they will or won't eat

My daughter's such a picky eater that she'll only eat plain pasta.

IDIOMS**have a sweet tooth**

to have a strong liking for sweet food

I've always had a sweet tooth. I can't resist chocolate.

hit the spot

to be exactly what you needed or wanted, especially with food or drink

That cup of tea really hit the spot after the long walk.

an acquired taste

something that you learn to enjoy over time, not immediately

Blue cheese is definitely an acquired taste.

bite off more than you can chew

to take on more than you can manage

He bit off more than he could chew when he agreed to cater for eighty people.

not my cup of tea

not something I enjoy or am interested in

Horror films aren't really my cup of tea.

a bite to eat

a small, quick meal or snack

Shall we grab a bite to eat before the film?

SET PHRASES

I'll have the...

used to tell a waiter or server which dish you are choosing

I'll have the sea bass, please, with a side salad.

Could you send this back for me?

used to ask a waiter to return a dish to the kitchen because something is wrong with it

Honestly, it's raw in the middle. Could you send this back for me?

Is there anything on the menu without...?

used to ask whether a dish suits, or can be adapted to suit, a dietary requirement

Is there anything on the menu without dairy? I can't eat cheese or cream.

Save room for dessert

used to tell someone not to fill up on the main course because there's more food coming

Don't eat too much bread. Save room for dessert!

MODERN SLANG

foodie

a person who is enthusiastic about food and cooking

She's a real foodie. She'll travel an hour for a good restaurant.

grub

food (informal, especially British)

Fancy some grub? I'm starving.